YOUR PATH TO GRADUATE SCHOOL

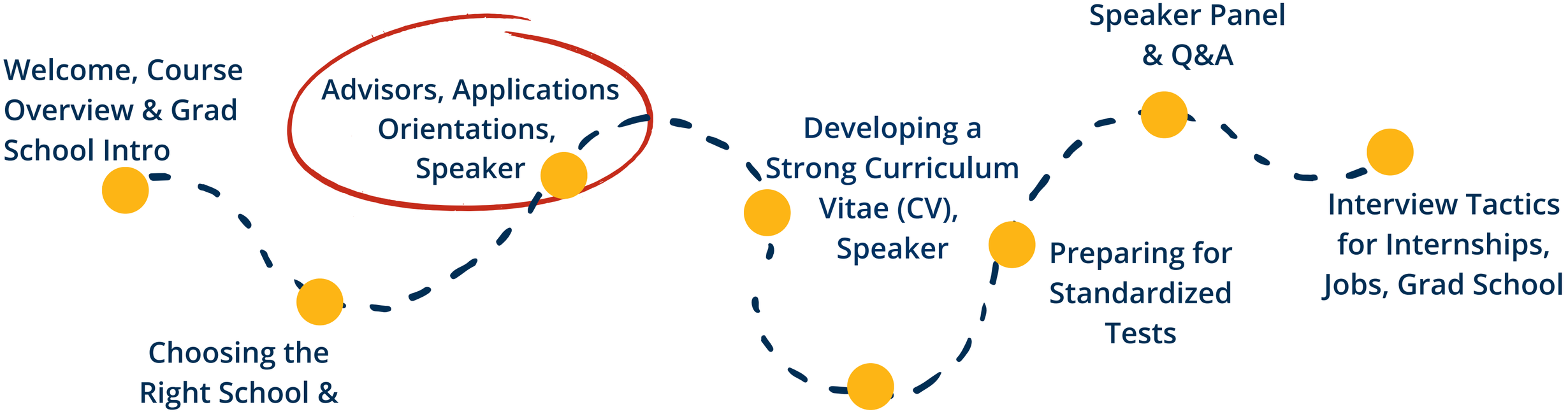
The Application Journey



©UC Berkeley, BGA Program
Course Creator: Sally Clapper

Berkeley
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

U.S. Graduate School Prep Course



One:One Coaching Sessions – get customized, expert advice!

©UC Berkeley, BGA Program

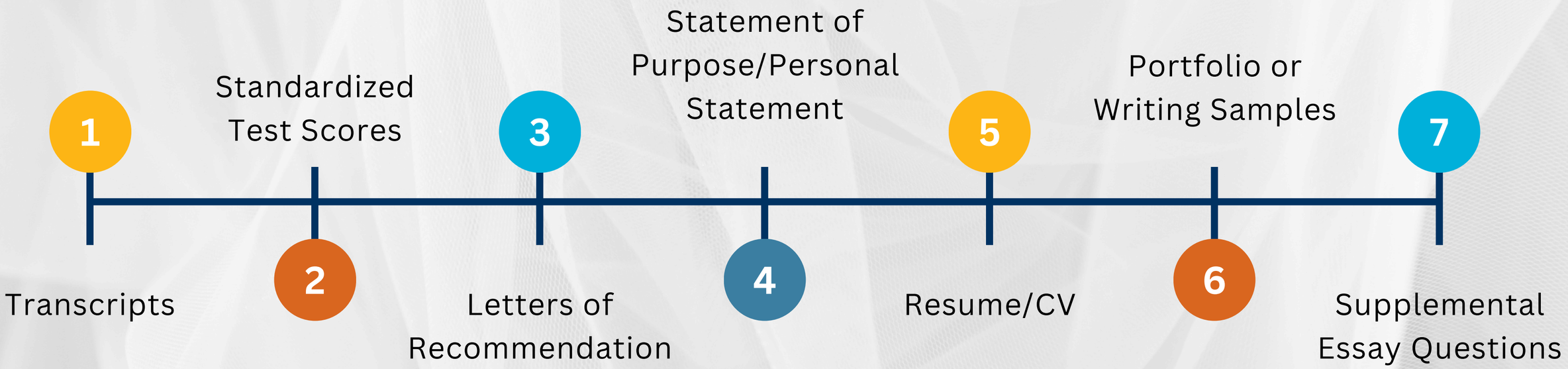
Course Creator & Instructor: Sally Clapper

THE MECHANICS OF APPLYING

QUICK OVERVIEW

Berkeley
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

REQUIRED DOCUMENTS



REQUIRED DOCUMENTS

TRANSCRIPTS

Request official transcripts from all institutions you have attended. Some programs may accept unofficial transcripts initially, but official ones will be required if admitted.

STANDARDIZED TEST SCORES

Depending on the program, you may need to submit GRE, GMAT, LSAT, TOEFL, or other test scores. Ensure you understand which tests are required and the minimum scores expected.

LETTERS OF RECOMMENDATION:

Typically, programs require 2-3 letters of recommendation (LORs) from professors or professionals who can speak to your academic and/or professional abilities. Request these well in advance.

SOP / PERSONAL STATEMENT

This is your chance to explain why you are interested in the program, your goals, and how the program aligns with your career aspirations. Tailor each statement to the specific program.

REQUIRED DOCUMENTS

RESUME/CV

Highlight relevant academic, professional, and extracurricular experiences. Focus on achievements and skills that are pertinent to the program.

PORTFOLIO, GITHUB, WRITING SAMPLES, VIDEOS, ETC.

If applicable, include samples of your work that demonstrate your skills and experience. Follow the program's guidelines for submission.

SUPPLEMENTAL ESSAY QUESTIONS

Check each program's website carefully and follow the prompts.

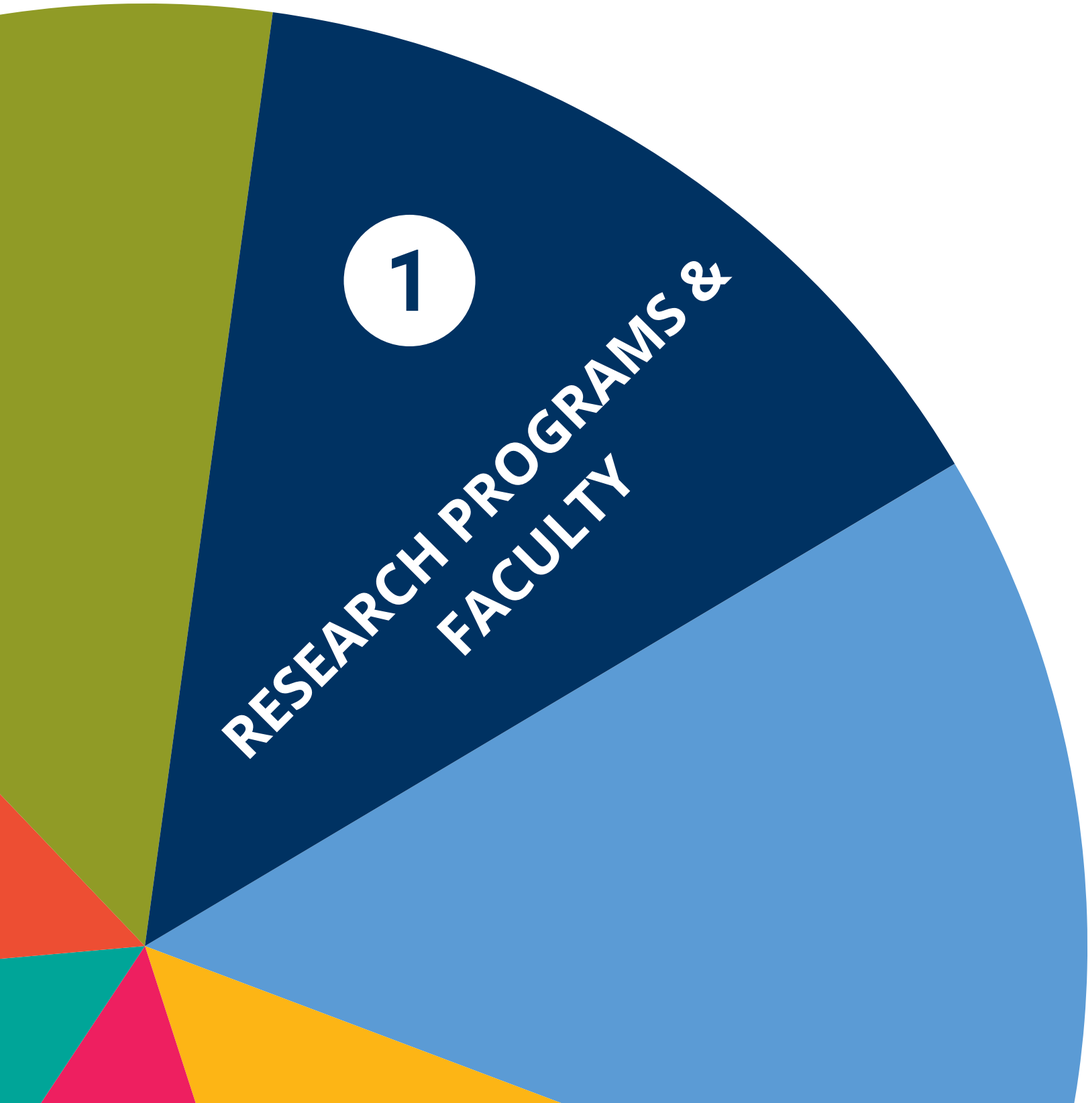
YOUR ADVISOR IS THE SINGLE MOST IMPORTANT FACTOR IF PURSUING A PHD

6 STRATEGIES TO FIND YOUR ADVISOR



©UC Berkeley, BGA Program

6 STRATEGIES TO FIND YOUR ADVISOR



PROGRAM WEBSITES

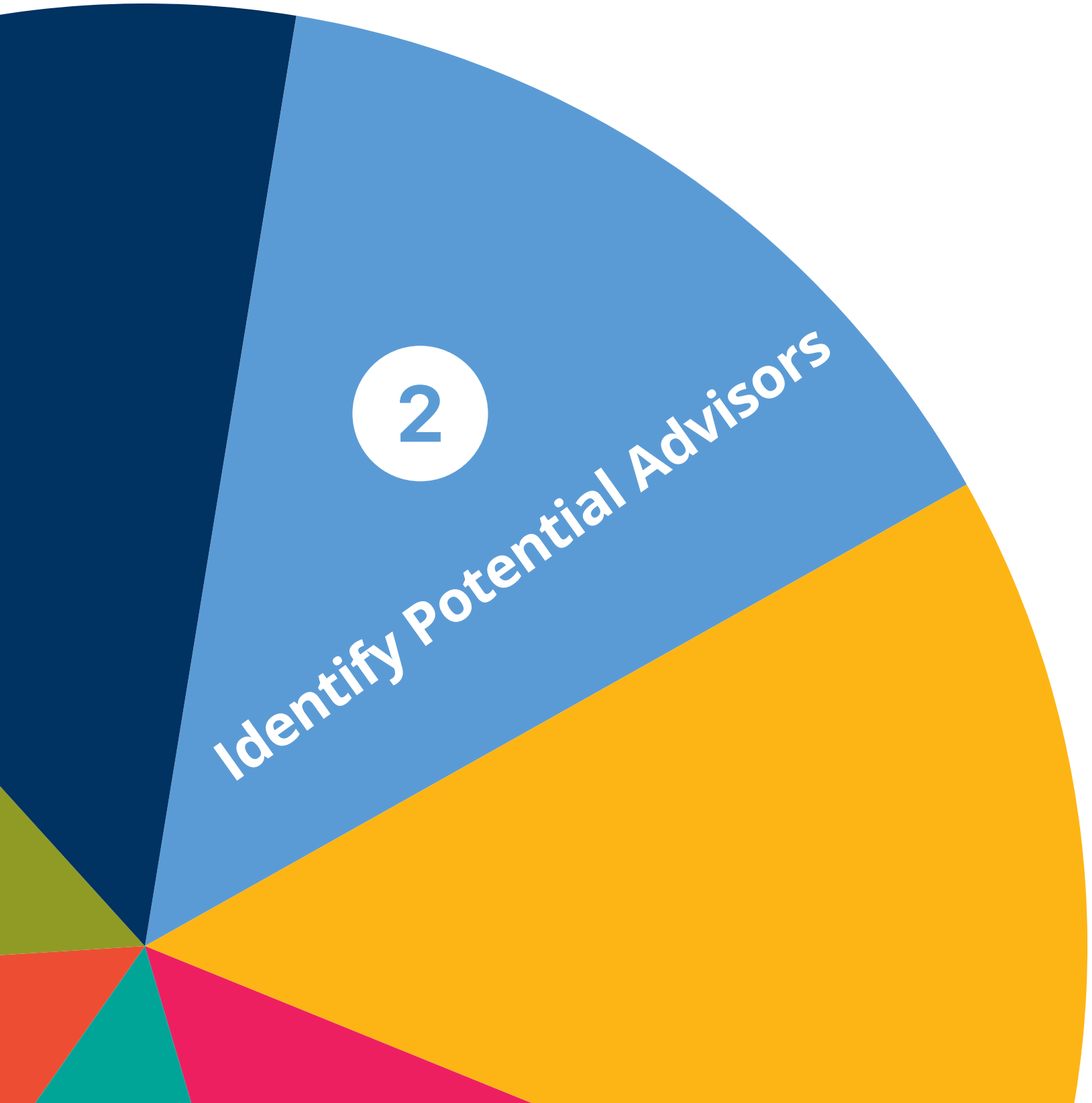
Start with the official websites of the programs you're interested in. Look at the faculty profiles, research areas, and recent publications.

FACULTY PUBLICATIONS

Read recent papers published by potential advisors to understand their research focus and methodology.

©UC Berkeley, BGA Program

6 STRATEGIES TO FIND YOUR ADVISOR



ADVISOR'S EXPERTISE

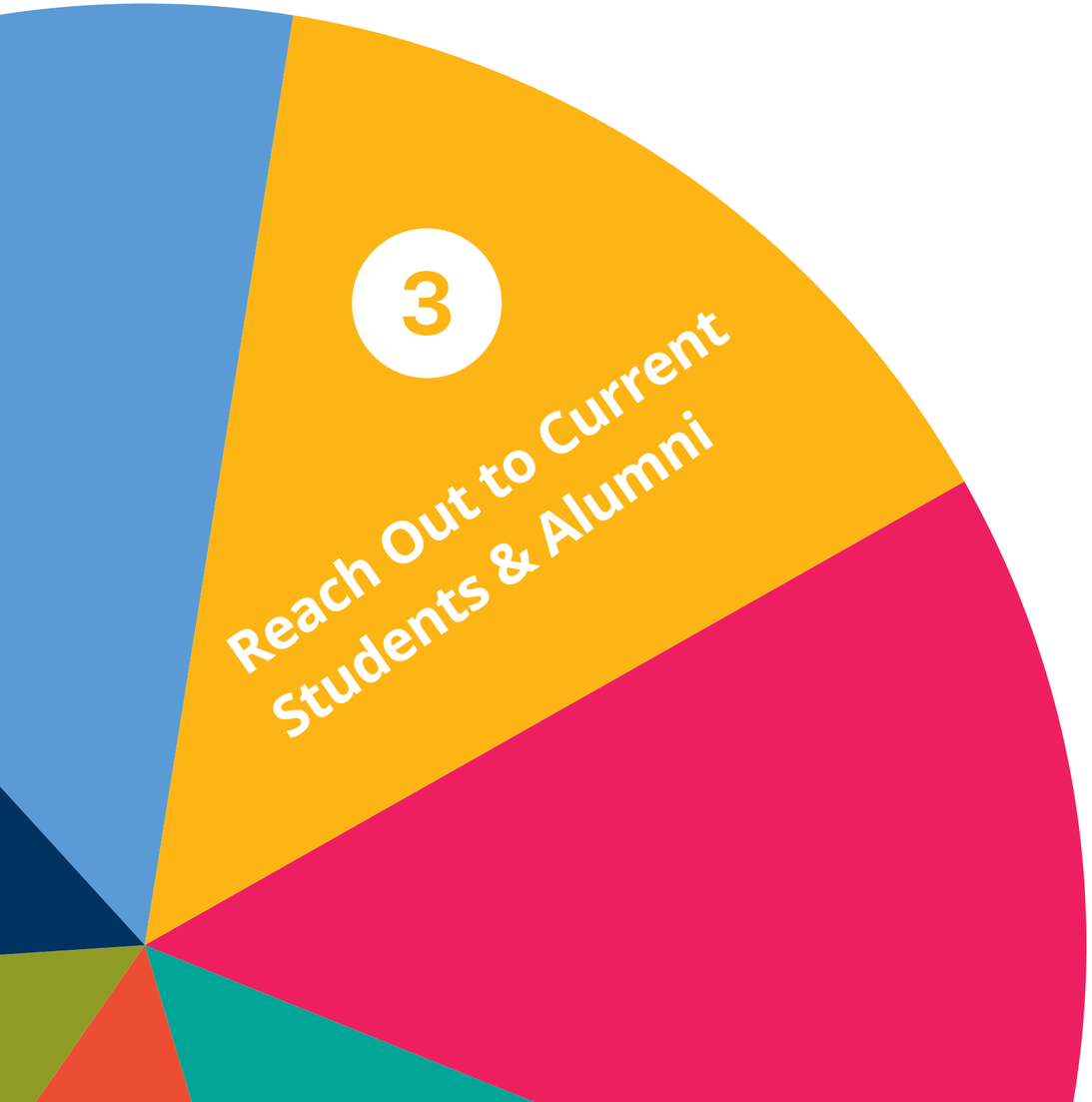
Ensure their expertise aligns with your interests and career goals.

RESEARCH ALIGNMENT

Check if the ongoing projects and lab culture match your academic interests.

©UC Berkeley, BGA Program

6 STRATEGIES TO FIND YOUR ADVISOR



CURRENT STUDENTS

Contact current students in the program to get insights into the advisor's mentoring style, lab environment, and program culture.

ALUMNI

Alumni can provide information on career outcomes and long-term benefits of the program.

©UC Berkeley, BGA Program

Berkeley
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

6 STRATEGIES TO FIND YOUR ADVISOR



INITIAL CONTACT

Send a well-crafted email expressing your interest in their work and how your interests align. Ask if they are taking new students.

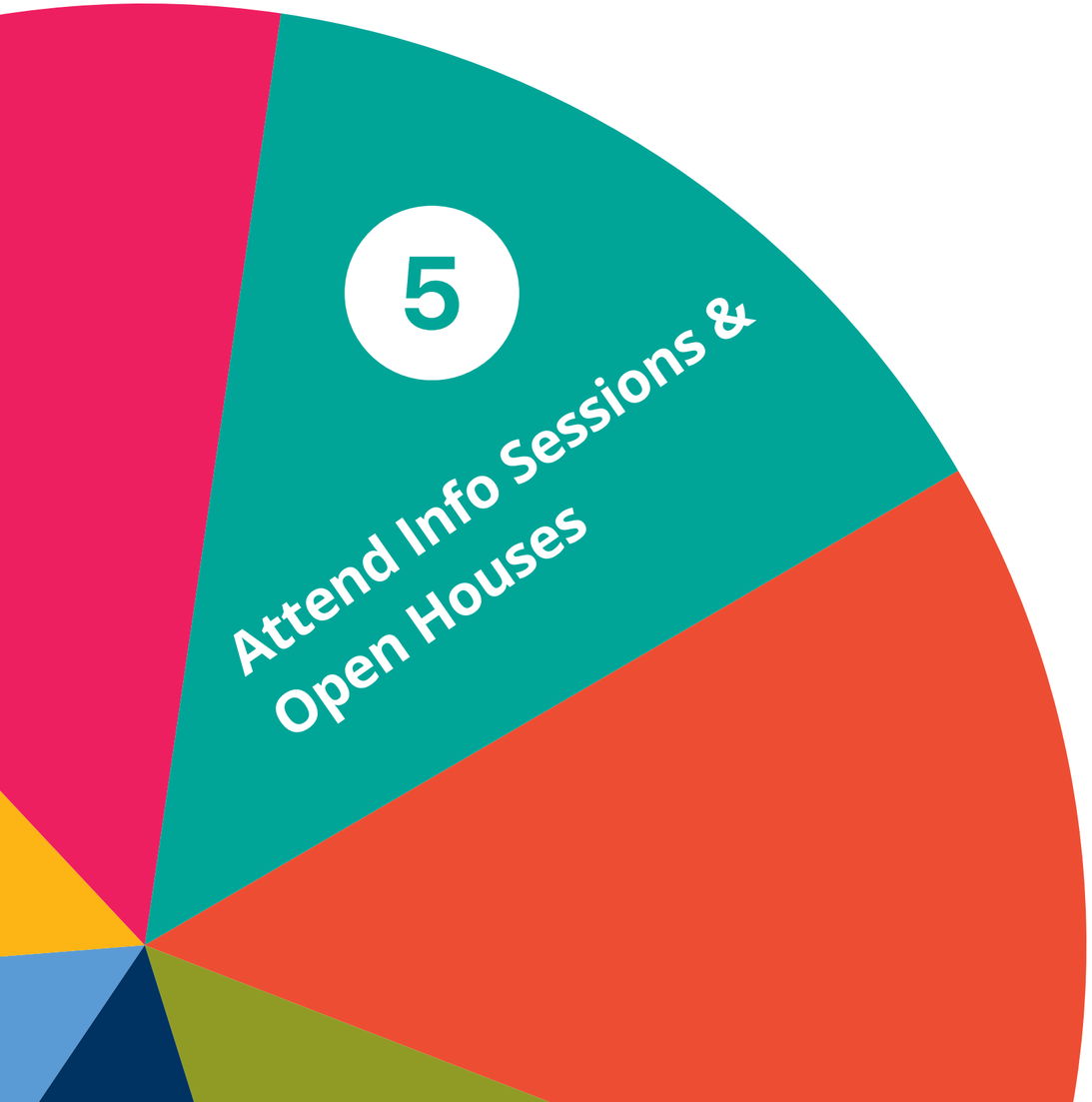
MEETINGS

Alumni can provide information on career outcomes and long-term benefits of the program.

©UC Berkeley, BGA Program

Berkeley
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

6 STRATEGIES TO FIND YOUR ADVISOR



PROGRAM INFO SESSIONS

Participate in webinars, info sessions, or open houses to learn more about the program, faculty, and research opportunities.

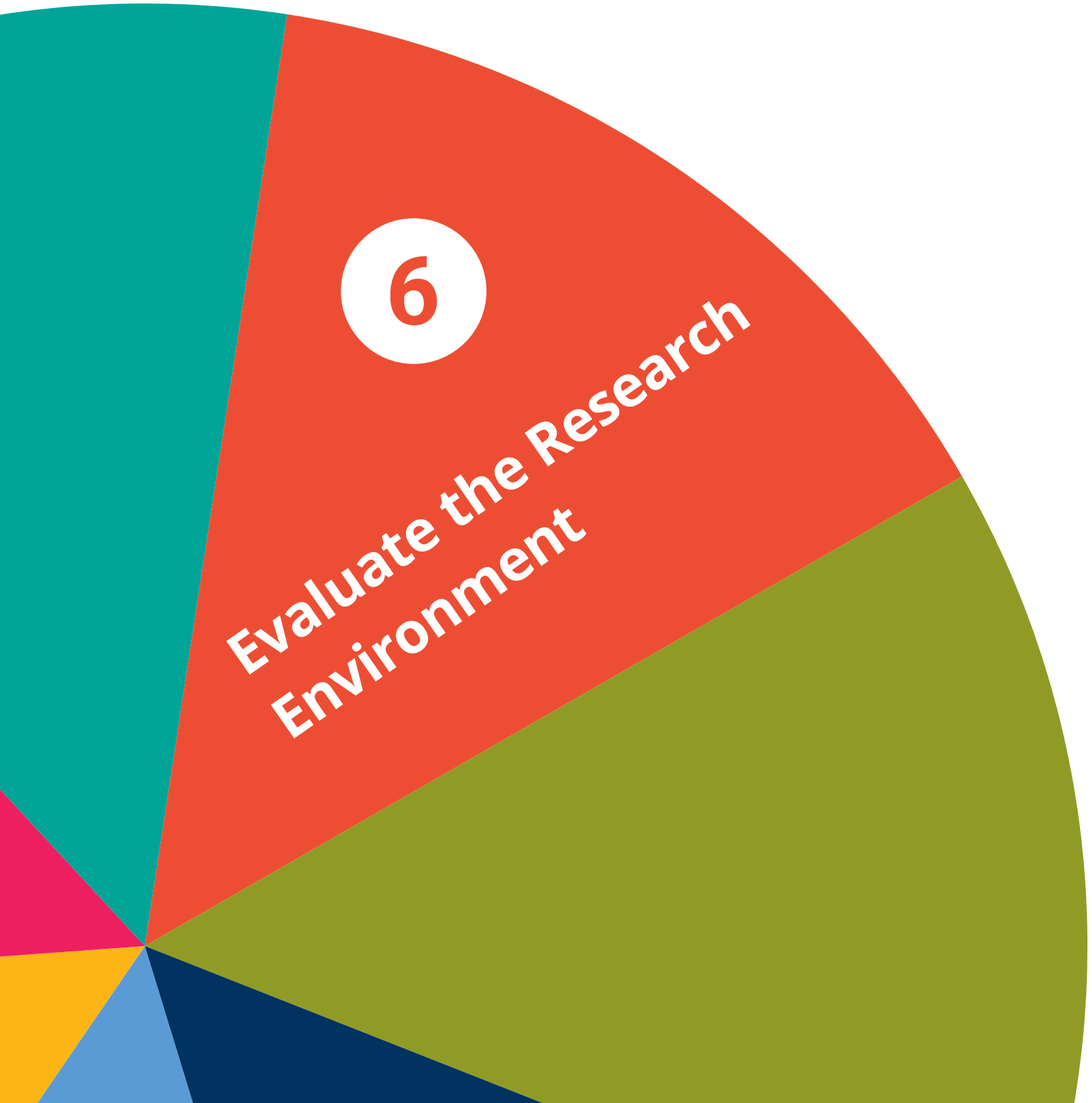
CONFERENCES AND WORKSHOPS

Attend conferences where potential advisors present their work. This allows you to see their research in action and network with other attendees.

©UC Berkeley, BGA Program

Berkeley
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

6 STRATEGIES TO FIND YOUR ADVISOR



LAB VISITS

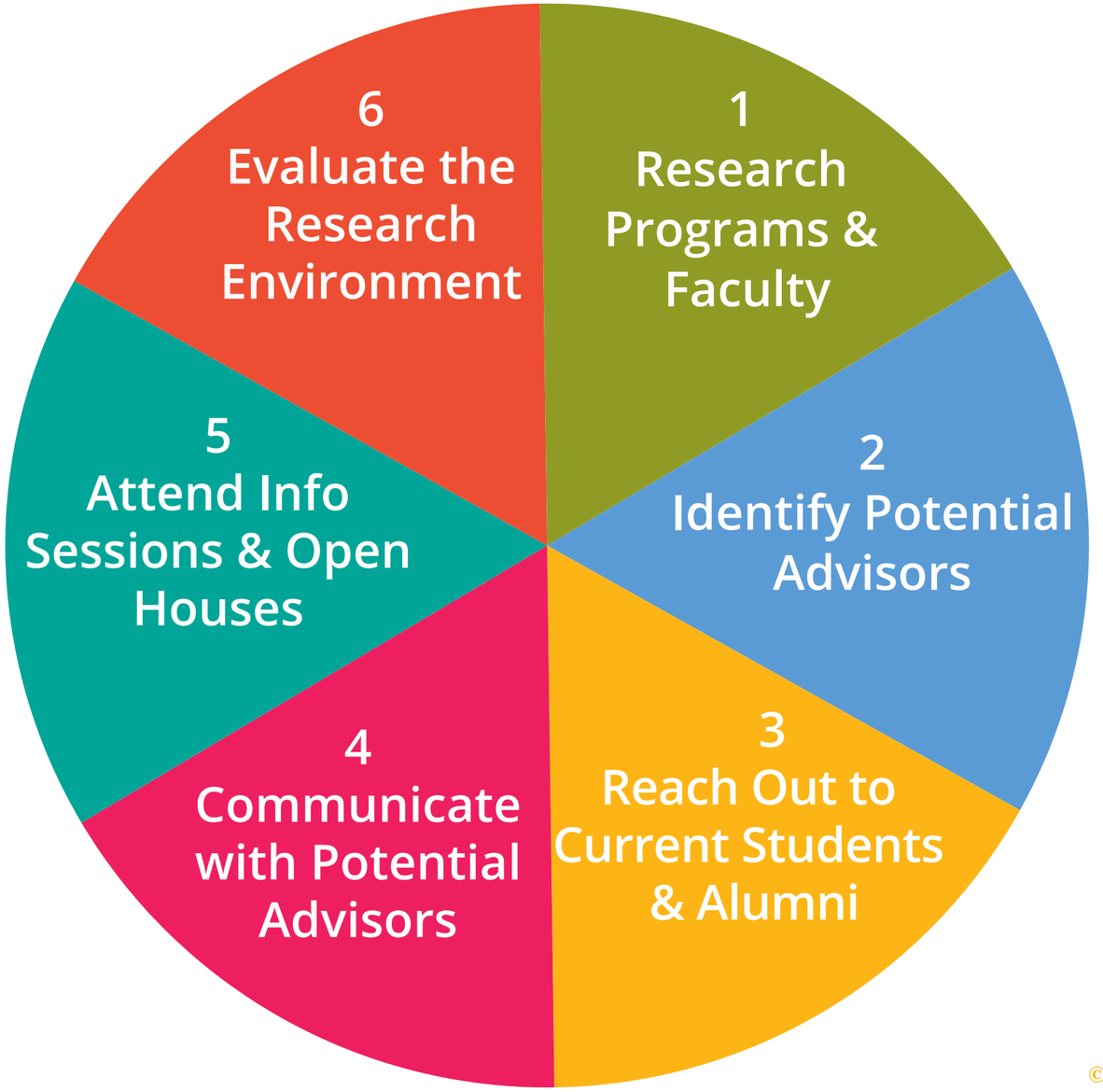
If possible, visit the campus and the labs to get a firsthand experience of the working environment.

COLLABORATIONS AND RESOURCES

Check for available resources, collaborations with other institutions, and funding opportunities.

©UC Berkeley, BGA Program

6 STRATEGIES TO FIND YOUR ADVISOR



©UC Berkeley, BGA Program



CRAFTING AN ELEVATOR PITCH

XYZ Formula for Career/Industry Pitch

~60 sec

I help X > do/achieve Y > by doing Z

EXAMPLE:
“I help small businesses grow by designing AI-powered marketing tools that improve efficiency and attract targeted audiences.”

Elevator Pitch – Research/Academic

~90–120 sec

Who You Are | **What You Study** | **Why It Matters** | **Next Steps**

“I’m a senior in Mechanical Engineering at Berkeley, working on AI-based optimization for energy systems. My research uses graph neural networks to improve power grid efficiency. I presented at IEEE last year, and I’m seeking PhD programs focused on sustainable urban infrastructure.”

XYZ Formula - Accomplishments

Accomplished [X] as measured by [Y], by doing [Z]

- **OK: "Won second place in hackathon."**
- **Better: "Won second place out of 50 teams in hackathon."**
- **Best: "Won second place out of 50 teams in hackathon at NJ Tech by working with two colleagues to develop an app that synchronizes mobile calendars.**

Write a Draft Elevator Pitch

Think of how’d you would introduce yourself to
a professor, admissions officer, or at a career fair or university orientation.

MAKING THE MOST OF INFORMATIONAL SESSIONS

A Guide for Prospective Graduate Students



Berkeley
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

WHY ATTENDING INFORMATIONAL SESSIONS GIVES YOU A COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE

Access to Exclusive Information

Meet Key People

Networking Opportunities

Show Genuine Interest

Detailed Presentations

Virtual sessions often include extensive slides and presentations with in-depth information about the program, which can help you understand the program more comprehensively.

Use in Applications

Information gained from these sessions can be valuable when writing your application essays or when reaching out to potential advisors. Mentioning specifics from these sessions can show that you have done your homework and are serious about the program.

Follow-Up Contact

These sessions provide you with a contact person to ask further questions, ensuring you have a direct line of communication with someone knowledgeable about the program.

Berkeley
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

WHAT TO EXPECT IN YOUR SESSION

- Program overview + curriculum highlights
- Admissions process & key dates
- Faculty introductions & research areas
- Financial aid/scholarships



Berkeley
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

WHAT TO EXPECT: STUDENT LIFE

- Hear from current students/alumni
- Learn about student life, clubs, research opportunities
- Dedicated time for Q&A



Berkeley
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

HOW TO PREPARE

📌 Check program websites for event listings

✍️ Prepare 2–3 questions in advance

📝 Take notes for future essays/applications

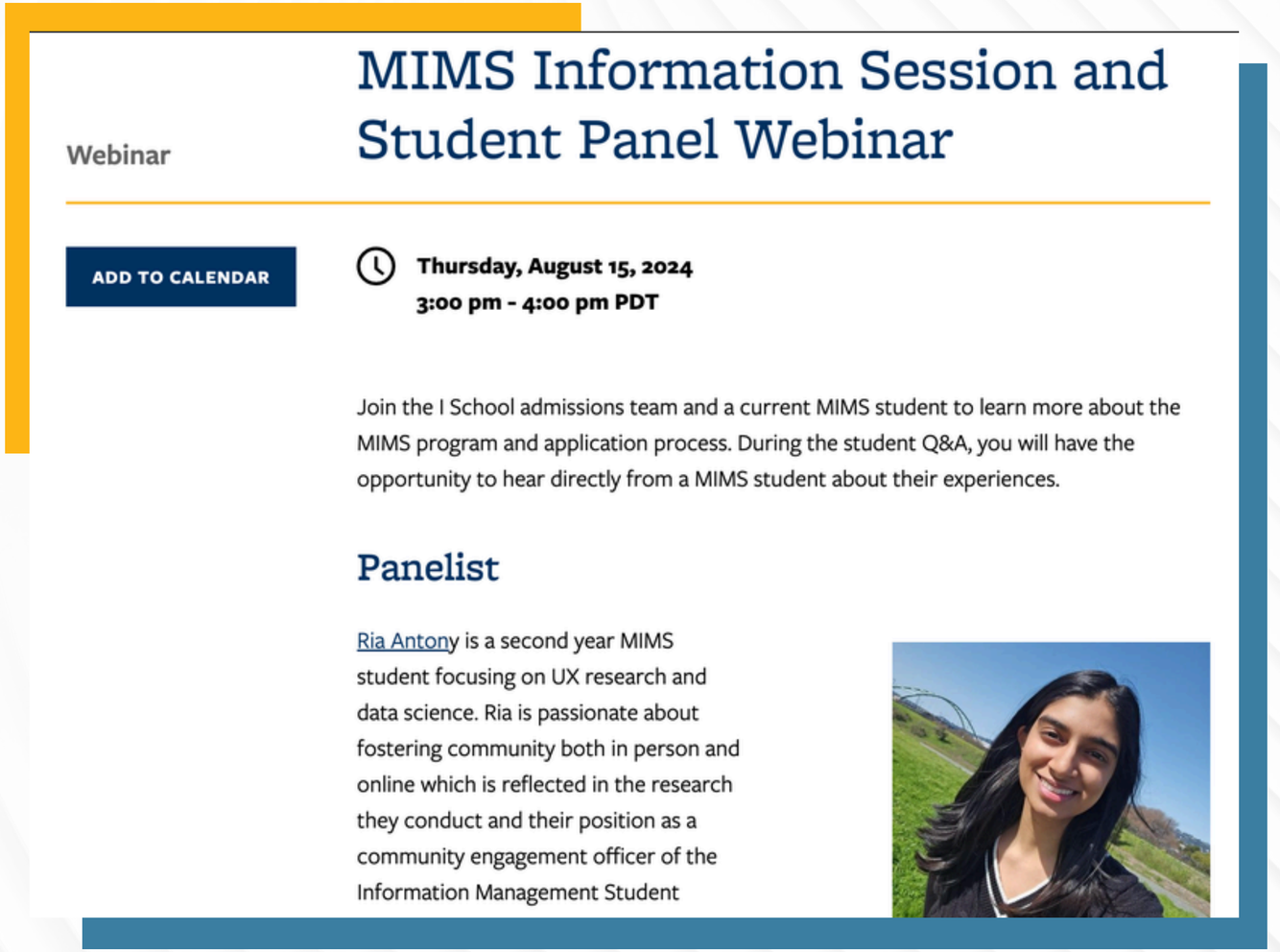
🤝 Use insights to tailor your SOP and advisor outreach



Berkeley
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

HOW TO FIND INFORMATIONAL SESSIONS

- Visit the program's website and look for the Events tab or page.
- **Example:** UC Berkeley School of Information Events.
- Use search engines to find event information by typing the program and university name + events.



Webinar

MIMS Information Session and Student Panel Webinar

ADD TO CALENDAR

Thursday, August 15, 2024
3:00 pm - 4:00 pm PDT

Join the I School admissions team and a current MIMS student to learn more about the MIMS program and application process. During the student Q&A, you will have the opportunity to hear directly from a MIMS student about their experiences.

Panelist

Ria Antony is a second year MIMS student focusing on UX research and data science. Ria is passionate about fostering community both in person and online which is reflected in the research they conduct and their position as a community engagement officer of the Information Management Student

Q&A SESSION: QUESTIONS TO ASK

- Specifics about curriculum or research opportunities
- Opportunities for feedback on the Statement of Purpose or essays
- SOP/essay expectations
- Support for international students
- Faculty accessibility & class size



Berkeley
UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA



Watch video on YouTube

Error 153

Video player configuration error



Your Turn

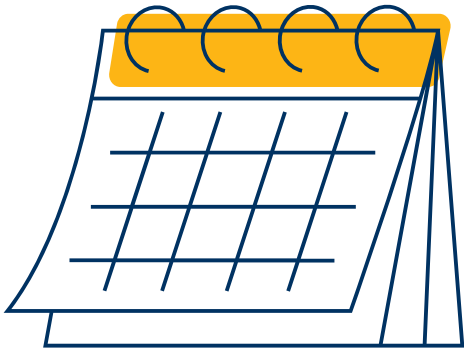

7:07
Reels
Jon Batiste!!! ❤️
ALL WE NEED IS A LITTLE LOVING
Likes
I Need You
el_del_audio
Follow
Jon Batiste - I Need You ...
Jon Batiste · I NEED YOU

Meet Gonzalo Vasquez

Current MBA student at Berkeley



COACHING



BOOK YOUR SESSION

https://calendly.com/career-compass/bga-coaching-session

Follow BGA on IG: bga_student
Connect with me on LinkedIn

Next Class
Thurs., Oct 9th
12:30pm - 2:30pm

Assignment 3

Due Wednesday, Oct. 8th

- **Share your Research/Academic “Pitch”**
  - background (who you are)
  - research focus (what you study)
  - impact (why it matters)
  - next steps

- **Upload your latest CV/Resume**

Exit Card

bit.ly/fall-session3

